ONLINE SCAMS MODULE

Developing Multilingual South African Context Online Cybersecurity Modules for Students

Module: Online Scams Learning Content and Knowledge Checks

Topic 1: Introduction to Online Scams

PART A: LEARNING CONTENT

Introduction

Online scams are deceptive activities designed to trick people into giving away money, personal information, account credentials, or access to digital accounts. Scammers use WhatsApp, SMS and email to make fraudulent messages appear legitimate.

What Is an Online Scam?

An online scam occurs when someone deliberately uses deception through a digital platform to persuade another person to take an action that benefits the scammer.

- Sending money.
- Sharing personal information.
- Revealing passwords, PINs or OTPs.
- Clicking a malicious or suspicious link.a
- Downloading an unsafe attachment.
- Providing access to an online account.

How Do Online Scams Work?

1. Attract attention.
2. Build trust.
3. Create pressure.
4. Request an action.
5. Benefit from the response.

Why Do People Fall for Scams?

- Trust the apparent sender.
- Fear losing money or account access.
- Become excited about a reward.
- Feel pressured by an urgent deadline.
- Are curious about a message.
- Believe the message is from an authority or trusted organisation.

Being deceived by a scam does not mean that someone is unintelligent. Scammers deliberately construct convincing situations to influence decisions.

South African Student Example

“STUDENT FUNDING NOTICE: URGENT: Your student allowance has been approved. Confirm your banking details within 30 minutes to avoid cancellation. Click here to continue.”

Activity: Spot the Scam

- Unexpected financial benefit
- Urgent deadline
- Request for personal/financial information
- Link requiring immediate action

Feedback: An unexpected financial offer combined with urgency and a request for information should be independently verified before action is taken.

Key Takeaway

STOP → THINK → VERIFY

PART B: KNOWLEDGE CHECK QUIZ

1. What is the main purpose of an online scam?

- A. Provide cybersecurity education
- B. Deceive a person for the scammer's benefit
- C. Improve online communication
- D. Verify identity

Correct answer: B

2. Which is a common characteristic?

- A. Always spelling mistakes
- B. Always unknown numbers
- C. Urgency or pressure
- D. Always identifiable by appearance

Correct answer: C

3. Unexpected money offer + link. What first?

- A. Click
- B. Forward
- C. Stop and verify independently
- D. Provide details

Correct answer: C

Topic 2: WhatsApp Scams

PART A: LEARNING CONTENT

Introduction

WhatsApp is widely used for personal, academic and social communication. This familiarity can be exploited by scammers who impersonate people or organisations.

Common Types

- Impersonation of friends, family, lecturers or organisations.
- Fake jobs, bursaries, competitions or rewards.
- Suspicious links.
- Emergency money requests.
- Requests for passwords, PINs or OTPs.

Warning Signs

- Unexpected requests
- Urgent language
- Requests for money
- Requests for sensitive information
- Suspicious links
- Unusual sender behaviour
- Unexpected rewards
- Impersonation

Example

“Hey, it's me. I lost my phone and I'm using this number temporarily. Please send me R800 urgently. I'll pay you back tonight.”

Interactive Activity

What should you do? A. Send money. B. Ask for banking details. C. Contact your friend through a trusted channel. D. Forward the message.

Feedback: A familiar name or profile picture does not prove identity. Verify unexpected requests independently.

Key Takeaway

Trust the person only after you verify the request.

PART B: KNOWLEDGE CHECK QUIZ

1. Which is a warning sign?

- A. Unexpected request for money
- B. Normal conversation
- C. Verified announcement
- D. Expected message

Correct answer: A

2. Friend requests money from a new number. What do you do?

- A. Send it
- B. Verify through another trusted channel
- C. Ask for OTP
- D. Forward

Correct answer: B

3. Why can impersonation scams work?

- A. They exploit trust
- B. Always contain malware
- C. Require no communication
- D. Only target businesses

Correct answer: A

Topic 3: SMS Scams

PART A: LEARNING CONTENT

Introduction

SMS scams use text messages to persuade recipients to take unsafe actions. They may appear to come from banks, delivery companies, mobile providers, government organisations or other trusted services.

Common Types

- Fake banking alerts
- Fake delivery messages
- Fake rewards
- Fake account warnings

Warning Signs

- Unexpected messages
- Urgent deadlines
- Suspicious links
- Requests for personal/banking information
- Unexpected payments
- Threats of account closure
- Offers too good to be true

Example

"URGENT! Your bank account will be blocked today. Confirm your account now: [link]"

Interactive Activity

Identify the warning signs.

Feedback: The message creates urgency, claims to represent a financial institution and directs the user to a link. Verify through an official channel instead.

Key Takeaway

Never allow an SMS to pressure you into an immediate financial or account decision.

PART B: KNOWLEDGE CHECK QUIZ

1. Unexpected banking SMS with a link?

- A. Click
- B. Reply
- C. Verify through the bank's official channel
- D. Forward

Correct answer: C

2. Which is a warning sign?

- A. Unexpected account warning
- B. Expected message
- C. Verified notification
- D. Ordinary conversation

Correct answer: A

3. Why treat suspicious links carefully?

- A. They may lead to fraudulent websites or unsafe actions
- B. They always delete your phone
- C. They cannot contain scams
- D. They are always safe

Correct answer: A

Topic 4: Email Scams

PART A: LEARNING CONTENT

Introduction

Email scams attempt to deceive users through fraudulent emails. They may imitate banks, universities, employers, online stores or other organisations.

Common Types

- Sender address
- Subject line
- Message content
- Links
- Attachments
- Requests

Warning Signs

- Unexpected sender
- Urgent/threatening subject
- Credential request
- Suspicious links
- Unexpected attachments
- Unusual request

Example

Subject: “URGENT – University Account Suspension”

“Your university account will be suspended today. Click the link below and confirm your password.”

Interactive Activity

Identify the sender, request, urgency, link and credential request.

Feedback: The email uses fear and urgency to encourage disclosure of credentials. Do not provide passwords through unexpected email requests; verify through an official channel.

Key Takeaway

Do not trust an email simply because it looks professional. Examine the sender, request, links and context.

PART B: KNOWLEDGE CHECK QUIZ

1. What should you examine?

- A. Sender information
- B. Font size only
- C. Paragraph count
- D. Signature colour

Correct answer: A

2. Email asks for your password. What do you do?

- A. Provide it
- B. Click
- C. Verify independently and do not disclose it
- D. Forward

Correct answer: C

3. Which is suspicious?

- A. Unexpected email + urgency + credential request
- B. Expected email
- C. Independently verified official information
- D. Routine notification

Correct answer: A

Topic 5: How Scammers Manipulate Victims

PART A: LEARNING CONTENT

Introduction

Scammers use social engineering and psychological manipulation to influence how people make decisions.

Common Manipulation Techniques

- Urgency – creates pressure and reduces time for verification.
- Fear – threatens a negative consequence.
- Authority – impersonates a trusted authority.
- Reward – uses excitement or financial incentive.
- Curiosity – encourages clicking to discover something.
- Trust and familiarity – impersonates someone the victim knows.

Activity: Identify the Manipulation Technique

"Your student account will be cancelled today unless you verify your information immediately."

A. Reward B. Fear and urgency C. Curiosity D. Entertainment

Feedback: B. The message uses fear of cancellation and urgency to pressure the recipient.

Key Takeaway

Scammers often manipulate emotions before asking victims to take an unsafe action.

PART B: KNOWLEDGE CHECK QUIZ

1. "Act within 10 minutes or lose your money."

- A. Urgency
- B. Curiosity
- C. Trust
- D. Reward

Correct answer: A

2. Why impersonate trusted organisations?

- A. To make communication appear credible
- B. To provide customer service
- C. To improve security
- D. To teach users

Correct answer: A

3. What is social engineering?

- A. Manipulating people into actions that benefit an attacker
- B. Hardware
- C. Social media
- D. Password manager

Correct answer: A

Topic 6: Investigating a Suspicious Message

PART A: LEARNING CONTENT

Introduction

Recognising that a message feels suspicious is useful, but students also need a systematic way to investigate it.

A Practical Investigation Process

6. STOP – Do not immediately click, reply, pay or provide information.
7. CHECK THE SENDER – Ask who sent it, whether it is expected and whether impersonation is possible.
8. EXAMINE THE REQUEST – Identify what the sender wants and whether money or sensitive information is requested.
9. CHECK THE DETAILS – Examine links, addresses, attachments, sender information and unusual language.
10. IDENTIFY WARNING SIGNS – Look for urgency, threats, rewards, impersonation and other indicators.
11. IDENTIFY MANIPULATION – Ask what the message is trying to make you feel.
12. VERIFY – Use an independent trusted source.
13. DECIDE – Choose the safest action: ignore/delete, report, contact the legitimate organisation, secure an account or seek assistance.

Activity: Investigate This Message

"URGENT: Your university account has been suspended. Click here within 15 minutes to restore access."

Feedback: The message contains urgency, impersonation and a request to click a link. Independently verify the claim rather than clicking the provided link.

Key Takeaway

Don't simply ask "Does this look real?" Ask "Can I verify that it is real?"

PART B: KNOWLEDGE CHECK QUIZ

1. What should you do first?

- A. Click
- B. STOP and avoid immediate action
- C. Send money
- D. Reply

Correct answer: B

2. Why independently verify?

- A. The message may provide false contact information
- B. Verification is unnecessary
- C. Impersonation is impossible
- D. Links are always trustworthy

Correct answer: A

3. Safest sequence?

- A. Click → provide → verify
- B. Respond → pay → investigate
- C. Stop → examine → identify → verify → decide
- D. Forward → click → respond

Correct answer: C

Topic 7: AI-Assisted Scam Investigation

PART A: LEARNING CONTENT

Introduction

AI can assist in analysing suspicious digital communications. However, AI should not be treated as an infallible authority. In this module, AI is proposed as a learning assistant: its purpose is to help students understand indicators and reasoning, not simply label a message.

What Can the Student Submit?

- Pasted WhatsApp messages
- SMS text
- Email content
- Screenshots
- Other suspicious digital communication

How the AI-Assisted Investigation Works

14. Student submits the suspicious communication.
15. Student makes an initial judgement and explains why.
16. AI analyses the content.
17. System identifies potential indicators such as urgency, impersonation, suspicious links, financial requests, sensitive-information requests and manipulative language.
18. AI explains the indicators.
19. Student compares their reasoning with the feedback.
20. Student receives a new scenario to apply what they learned.

Example

"URGENT! Your student funding has been suspended. Verify your account within 30 minutes using this link."

- Urgency – a 30-minute deadline.
- Impersonation – claims to represent a student funding organisation.
- Suspicious link – directs the student to a link rather than an independently verified official website.

AI Limitations

- AI can make mistakes.
- A "safe" classification does not guarantee safety.
- A "suspicious" classification does not automatically prove fraud.
- Important decisions should be independently verified.
- AI output is assistance, not definitive proof.

Privacy and Safe Submission

- Passwords
- OTPs
- Banking details
- Identity numbers
- Private conversations
- Unnecessary personal information

Where possible, identifying information should be removed before submission.

Activity: Investigate With AI

21. Make your own assessment.
22. Identify at least two warning signs.
23. Submit the content to the AI-assisted tool.
24. Compare your assessment with the AI analysis.
25. Identify something you noticed and something you initially missed.
26. Complete a new scenario.

Key Takeaway

Use AI to support your investigation, not to replace your judgement.

PART B: KNOWLEDGE CHECK QUIZ

1. Primary educational purpose of the AI-assisted feature?

- A. Make all decisions
- B. Replace learning
- C. Help students analyse suspicious communications and understand warning signs
- D. Guarantee legitimacy

Correct answer: C

2. Which should NOT be uploaded?

- A. Fictional scam example
- B. Message with sensitive banking information
- C. Simulated SMS
- D. Synthetic email

Correct answer: B

3. Why not blindly trust AI?

- A. AI can make mistakes
- B. AI never analyses messages
- C. AI cannot identify patterns
- D. AI is always incorrect

Correct answer: A

Topic 8: Responding to an Online Scam

PART A: LEARNING CONTENT

Introduction

Identifying a scam is only one part of staying safe. Students also need to know what to do when they encounter a suspicious message or realise that they may have interacted with a scam.

If You Receive a Suspicious Message

Do not:

- Click suspicious links.
- Download unexpected attachments.
- Send money.
- Provide passwords or OTPs.
- Continue communicating with the scammer unnecessarily.

Do:

- Stop and assess the message.
- Verify the information independently.
- Report suspicious content where appropriate.
- Delete or block the sender where appropriate.

If You Have Already Responded

27. Stop further communication.
28. Secure affected accounts.
29. Change compromised credentials.
30. Contact the relevant organisation through an official channel.
31. Monitor accounts for suspicious activity.
32. Report the incident through appropriate channels.
33. Seek assistance if money or sensitive information has been lost.

Activity: What Would You Do?

You clicked a suspicious link and entered your login credentials. You now realise that the message may have been a scam.

A. Ignore it.
B. Continue communicating with the sender.
C. Secure the account and contact the legitimate organisation through an official channel.
D. Forward the link.

Feedback: C. Acting quickly can reduce further harm. Secure the account and contact the legitimate organisation through an independently verified channel.

Key Takeaway

If you think you have been scammed, don't hide it or ignore it. Act quickly to reduce potential harm.

PART B: KNOWLEDGE CHECK QUIZ

1. After clicking a suspicious link and providing a password?

- A. Do nothing
- B. Secure the account and change the compromised password
- C. Send the password to the sender
- D. Forward the link

Correct answer: B

2. How verify a suspicious banking message?

- A. Link in the message
- B. Number provided by sender
- C. Independently obtained official channel
- D. Another suspicious message

Correct answer: C

3. Why report?

- A. It can help organisations and relevant authorities respond
- B. It guarantees arrest
- C. Makes the message legitimate
- D. Prevents all future scams

Correct answer: A

Topic 9: Apply and Test Your Knowledge

PART A: LEARNING CONTENT

Introduction

The final section allows students to apply what they have learned to unfamiliar situations. The purpose is to determine whether students can identify, investigate and respond to suspicious communications.

Scenario 1: WhatsApp

"Hi, I'm from your university's student support office. Your R3,000 emergency payment has been approved. Send your banking details now so we can process it."

34. Identify warning signs.
35. Identify the manipulation technique.
36. Decide whether it is suspicious.
37. Explain your reasoning.
38. Select the safest response.

Scenario 2: SMS

"URGENT: Your parcel is being returned today. Pay R20 delivery fee here: [link]."

Students must investigate the message using the process from Topic 6.

Scenario 3: Email

Subject: “Final Warning – Account Suspension”

“Your university account will be disabled within 24 hours. Click here and provide your password to prevent suspension.”

Students must examine the sender, request, urgency, link and potential manipulation.

Scenario 4: AI-Assisted Investigation

39. Make your own judgement.
40. Identify warning signs.
41. Explain your reasoning.
42. Submit the example to the AI-assisted investigation tool.
43. Review the AI explanation.
44. Compare your initial judgement with AI feedback.
45. Make a final decision.

Reflection Activity

What warning sign did you identify first?

Did the AI identify any indicators that you missed?

What will you do differently when you receive a suspicious message in the future?

Final Key Takeaway

RECOGNISE → INVESTIGATE → DECIDE → RESPOND

PART B: FINAL KNOWLEDGE CHECK

1. Unexpected WhatsApp money offer + banking details. Safest response?

- A. Provide details
- B. Click
- C. Independently verify before action
- D. Forward

Correct answer: C

2. Strongest reason to treat a message as suspicious?

- A. Urgency + unexpected request + suspicious link
- B. Normal conversation + expected sender
- C. Official information independently verified
- D. Routine notification

Correct answer: A

3. Purpose of AI-assisted investigation?

- A. Replace judgement
- B. Guarantee every message is a scam

- C. Support identification and understanding of potential indicators
- D. Collect private messages

Correct answer: C

4. Best process?

- A. Click → respond → verify
- B. Trust → act → investigate
- C. Recognise → investigate → decide → respond
- D. Ignore → forward → respond

Correct answer: C

5. Unsure whether a suspicious message is legitimate?

- A. Trust it because it looks professional
- B. Use the investigation process, independently verify and use AI assistance where appropriate
- C. Send money
- D. Give the sender an OTP

Correct answer: B